



Prompt: Give me a 50-minute lesson plan on thesis statements

Lesson Plan:

Here is a 50-minute lesson plan for teaching **thesis statements** to middle or high school students (adaptable for early college).

Topic: Writing Strong, Arguable Thesis Statements

Objective: Students will be able to distinguish between weak and strong thesis statements and write a clear, arguable thesis for a given prompt.

Materials: Whiteboard/projector, index cards or sticky notes, handout with sample prompts

Lesson Timeline (50 minutes)

1. Hook & Diagnostic (5 minutes)

- **Activity: “Agree or Disagree”**
 - Project two simple statements about a familiar topic (e.g., school uniforms or social media).
 - *Statement A:* “School uniforms have both good and bad points.”
 - *Statement B:* “School uniforms should be required because they reduce bullying and economic stress.”
 - Ask: *Which one could start a real argument? Which one is just an observation?*
- **Purpose:** Activate prior knowledge. Introduce the idea that a thesis must take a stand.

2. Direct Instruction: The 3 Rules (10 minutes)

- **Define:** “A thesis statement is 1-2 sentences at the end of your introduction. It tells the reader your main claim and how you will support it.”
- **Teach the “So What? Who Cares?” Rule:**
 - Weak: “This paper will discuss climate change.” (No argument)
 - Strong: “Governments should prioritize renewable energy over fossil fuels to slow climate change.”
- **The 3 Rules of a Strong Thesis (use a visual anchor chart):**
 1. **Arguable** – Someone could reasonably disagree.
 2. **Specific** – Not vague (avoid “many things,” “society,” “good/bad”).
 3. **Supportable** – You can find evidence for it.
- **Quick Check:** Show 3 sample sentences; students give thumbs up/down for each rule.

3. Guided Practice: Thesis Surgery (15 minutes)

- **Activity:** Students work in pairs to “fix” weak thesis statements.
- **Distribute handout or project these weak examples:**
 1. “*There are pros and cons to online learning.*” (Fix: Make it arguable)
 2. “*This essay will tell you about why recycling is important.*” (Fix: Remove announcement language)
 3. “*Video games are bad.*” (Fix: Add specific reason)
- **Pairs rewrite** each sentence into a stronger thesis.
- **Share-out:** Call on 2-3 pairs to share one fix. Discuss changes.

4. Independent Application (12 minutes)

- **Activity: Write Your Own**
 - Provide 2 prompts (choose one to write for):
 - *Prompt A (Literature):* In *The Hunger Games* or another known novel, does the main character cause their own success, or does luck play a bigger role? Write a thesis.
 - *Prompt B (Argument):* Should schools ban cell phones during the school day? Write a thesis.
 - Students write **one thesis statement** on an index card/sticky note.
- **Differentiation:** Offer sentence frames:
 - *Although some believe X, this evidence shows Y because Z.*
 - *[Subject] should/should not [action] because [reason 1] and [reason 2].*

5. Exit Ticket & Wrap-Up (8 minutes)

- **Peer Review (5 min):** Students swap cards with a partner. Partner checks:
 - Is it arguable? (Yes/No)
 - Is it specific? (Yes/No)
 - Does it answer the prompt? (Yes/No)
 - **Final Share (3 min):** Ask 2-3 volunteers to read their partner's approved thesis aloud. Reiterate the 3 rules as students leave.
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Homework / Extension

- **Revise your exit ticket thesis** into a complete introductory paragraph (hook + background + thesis).
- **Find a thesis** in an editorial or op-ed online. Copy it and identify the 3 rules in action.

Teacher Notes

- If students struggle with “arguable,” use binary debates (dogs vs. cats, summer vs. winter) to practice first.
- For advanced students, add a “counterargument” requirement (e.g., “*Although some argue X, Y is more effective because...*”).